

or Greek, which contained any other version than the official one were systematically destroyed. Just as the old Greek version of Daniel narrowly escaped the fate which befell its Semitic original, being saved only in a single Greek codex and a secondary version, so this portion of the condemned Esdras recension was rescued by a lucky chance. There was only one such fragment, and all of our "I Esdras" texts and translations go back to it. It probably consisted of a few quires plucked out of the middle of a codex. The first page of the rescued fragment began with II Chron. 35:1; and the last words on the last page were *καὶ ἐπισυνήχθησαν*, which in this version had been the first words of Neh. 8:13.

And it is certain, finally, that the manuscript from which this piece survived was Greek, not Semitic. There never existed a Hebrew-Aramaic fragment of the same extent as our First Esdras. Conclusive proof of this statement is found in the closing words, for in the Hebrew text Neh. 8:13 begins with *וביום השני*, not with the verb.

Whether accidentally rescued or deliberately excised, it is evident that this fragment was not altered nor edited in any way by those who first preserved it by itself. No attempt was made to give it a suitable beginning, nor even to complete the obviously unfinished sentence with which it ends.¹⁷ In every library of ancient manuscripts there are to be found similar fragments, consisting generally of a few quires surviving from codices of which the remainder has been lost;¹⁸ fragments almost always through accident, but sometimes also through selection. In the sense in which any one of these might be called a "book," First Esdras may be given that designation, but in no other sense.

¹⁷ Except in the Lagarde Greek recension, which here, as in some other places (compare what was said above regarding the text of 4:39) has been deliberately "revised."

¹⁸ Compare, for example, the accidental loss of the first part of the Peshitto version of Tobit, which has totally disappeared.